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# Mapping Experimental Research In the Social Sciences. A Systematic Review of Latin America 1990–2026

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**Abstract Text:**
Experimental methods have revolutionized causal inference, but their global distribution remains highly stratified. While Latin America provides a critical setting for studying inequality and informality, the region's actual role in producing experimental knowledge remains unclear. This project presents a systematic mapping of experimental social science connected to Latin America to interrogate the geopolitics of academic knowledge.

We analyze 1137 unique records indexed in the Web of Science Core Collection between 1990 and 2026, encompassing various approaches (including survey, field, laboratory, conjoint, vignette, and audit designs). To understand these dynamics, we distinguish between regional production and regional focus. We define regional production as research featuring at least one Latin American institutional affiliation, and regional focus as studies conducted about Latin America regardless of author location. Our corpus yields 716 records of regional production and 839 studies about the region, with only 418 meeting both criteria. We compare publication trends, disciplinary composition, and experimental designs while establishing benchmarks against the United States. Furthermore, we apply topic modeling to map the main thematic areas across the social sciences.

Preliminary findings reveal an explosive expansion of experimental research after 2015, alongside deep disciplinary divides. Economics and Political Science dominate the corpus, while Sociology remains marginal. Brazil, Chile, Colombia, and Mexico drive most local output. Yet, a profound structural gap persists. By 2025, Latin American experimental output reached just 5.8 records per 1000 publications, compared to 16.4 in the United States.

We conclude by discussing how these patterns reflect broader inequalities in global academic collaborations. Acknowledging limitations regarding database coverage and affiliation metrics, this mapping highlights the need to decentralize knowledge production and foster endogenous experimental sociology.

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